

As Wicca has evolved, most of Gardner's instructions—such as his assertion that “to work magic you must be naked”—are no longer followed, but some practices remain. The first is the creation of a circle, marked out by sprinkling exorcised water, by an athame (dagger), or by candles. Inside the circle, the worshippers believe that they can separate themselves from the material world. While chanting spells, charms, and incantations (many introduced by Doreen Valiente); making potions; and dancing, participants use a variety of objects to enhance the ritual: crystals, candles, herbs (especially potent), incense, oils, and tarot cards.

These rituals have links to the High Magic of the Freemasons (see pp.194–197) but also to the practices of cunning folk and folk magic. Today, rituals can take on whatever meaning their practitioners choose, provided their intentions are benign.

▼ Spiral dance

Spiritualist Miriam Simos, better known as Starhawk, inspired the performance of the first spiral dance in 1979. This joyous affirmation of pagan feminism is held every year at Samhain (Halloween), especially in the US.



▲ Wicca wedding

Since the late 1960s, handfastings (Wiccan weddings) have become more popular. This couple were conjoined in 2008. The priest wore a ram's horns to signify the Horned God.

Ever-growing appeal of magic

The global appeal of Wicca has been extraordinary. It has overcome the common presumption of witchcraft as dark and sinister, and as the exclusive preserve of women. Wicca attracted the counterculture of the 1960s, and it has since chimed with the nonjudgmental values of

